

Critical Reflection on Postcolonialism as of Wednesday, 21th September 2022
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Addressing the cleverly formed system that is colonialism, is a vast and varied process that is still filtering through multiple degrees of practice in the Architectural field.

There is a Philosophy of Deconstruction to be found here, as aptly described in Homi Bhabha's "Third Space" theories.

I am particularly fond of this notion, as it is the practice of recognising Colonialism as a Part of the Oppressed Identity, as well as Not-Colonialism.

i.e. One must acknowledge that a building is constructed on this particular site, while at the same time, something before it existed that is no longer there (pre-colonial era). Something will also exist after it (post-colonial to current era) that builds itself rooted in an identity of both colonial outcome and pre-colonial outcome.

It is impossible to undo what has been done. I am a South African Indian, a product of Colonialism: I would not relinquish my South African Identity in favour of abolishing the effects of colonialism entirely. Instead I must rediscover and reinterpret my Indian roots within the South African context.

A feat that is easier said than done, this is one individual example of how a post colonial mindset requires the thinking of two frames of existence.

A true contrarian cannot oppose everything that is conforming, as that is a conformist of a different kind - similarly, post colonial thought should not consist only of antagonising colonialism, as this in itself centres its identity around colonialism. The narrative still belongs to the colonial power in this example.

True post-colonial thought in Architecture may not have as much to do with buildings as much as it does with the processes of practice.

The idea of what we consider to be Architecture is greatly skewed towards the Eurocentric. The values placed (or I should say, imposed) on students in Architectural education largely focuses on White Excellence.

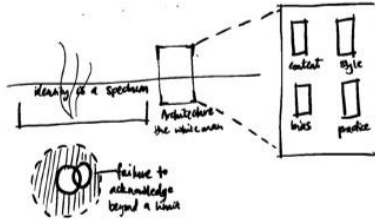
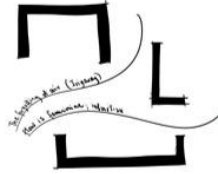
History lectures revolve around White Male Architects, the importance of Modernism, the starchitects of the 21st century vision; and the rigid aspiration to imitate such examples.

The student is made to either be a cheap imitation of a White Man, or else, is designated into a box of "things that do not work" since any antagonist to the Colonial is considered inferior or inadequate or invalid.

A poem I have written explains this in prose:

A line I draw is a line imitating the line of a white man. And if it is not a line it is not architecture. I am not that architecture. I cannot see it; and they cannot see what I can see.

I do not want to design buildings I have hardly ever noticed. They are important and I care for them, but I care more for the space within. I must respect the love of performance that is inherent in my people.



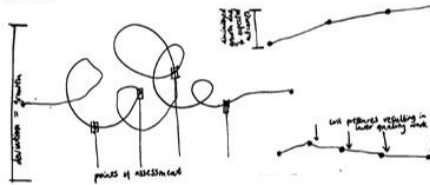
Even this prose is architecture as I have understood it to be a culmination or relationship between space and entities. I now know I do not have to explain myself, not to those who can easily read the biographies of frank and mies and norman and blake who likely started drawing lines just because they felt like it. All architectural expression is some degree of vanity, ego, indulgence. In the exciting and the eclectic; some of that looks white and some of me looks Indian and some of this looks black – there are strong values in all, and I know them well.

I do not know where I come from, and they do not want me to explore this. They forced me to make a building in their image, favouring those of a preferred visage. In defying the white man, I was still responding to the white man. I could not give them a good enough reason why. It did not feel right.

The way we do things is not refined, it is not finished, it is not proper - intuition does not have words and I cannot speak these words in English as well as I do in my head.

I do not listen and write; I practice and engage.

We speak when spoken to, but now I am loud and outspoken, it is a need to be heard. Most of us fear speaking too loudly.



The biopic of my lecturing body would not pass the Bechdel test. My value is measured in a linear way I cannot align myself with. There is little room for me to breathe – creativity works in a different way. I wish they measured my growth instead of my aesthetics. They saw themselves in me, and they found it unfair that I did not suffer as they had – and so they made it their task to behave as the white man that was no longer there. They said many things I choose not to remember, but I will not forget what I learned.

There is always an "us" and a "them."

My experience has made me resilient, but I am still unlike my predecessors. "Today's kids are not built the same" – why should they be? I will become what they should have been: a good guide – I am here to look, to seek, to learn and to listen. I demand the same in return.

I am not just a student, I am a teacher, I am a carrier of generations of thought, including theirs.

This is a very strong line.